

The Canvas, Whose Stories Are Us





CREATIVE WRITING 10 THW
LITERARY FOLIO

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WHAT UNDER THE BLANKET

Brix Anthony C. Cruz

I have always thought of a blanket the way I thought of love, and that everyone must not be left out in the cold. The blanket, however, was not the case for me. Among the three of us, I was always being pointed out as the black sheep. My parents' children were all outgoing, lively, and extroverted—and the equation never balanced when I plugged myself into it. Every time we went out, the chairs seemed to be so distant from me. When their laughter never reached me, I knew exactly how alienated I was and I knew how petty this was, but you could not blame the younger version of myself every time he felt estranged when his father blatantly said that his youngest son is his favorite among us. This has been the constant image they've been instilling in me, and perhaps it worked. Every time that there was a gathering, whether it may be just outside of my room or a family outing, they never helped themselves to think of me, unless they had something to brag about us. One thing also about us is that I am the only one who always wants to push myself beyond what I could do, and it has been a constant reminder of me to them. Ga-graduate 'yung anak ko na may mabigat sa leeg niya. I have been subjected to this idealized image that I eventually found myself being alienated from my own family.

But amidst this alienation, only one person could make me feel again. My nanay decided to live in Pangasinan when my tatay passed away. That's how we addressed them so that we won't mistake them for my grandfather and grandmother on my father's side. And we only visited her every once in a while to make sure she was still in good shape. When my family decided to pay her a visit one time in summer, I told them that I would stay with her, while my family would then roam around Manila to enjoy the heat. The tricycle's engine starting still echoes in my mind when they were about to leave only the two of us.

My nanay and I had a serene life for months. Although we slept at the same time in the same blanket, our bed always had an extra space for me in the morning. I would then be woken up by the delicious smell of fried rice partnered with a sunny-side up egg. It was a typical morning for a child to experience, and I, in retrospect, realized that what made it so special was that it was my first time to have that kind of childhood memory. In Bulacan, I would just wake up early to avoid being late in school and then play on our computer once I got back to our house.

I really could not feel the warmth brought by my mother's love. Ever since I was child, her intimacy always belonged to my youngest sibling. When the moment came that I asked and confronted her, she just casually said that among us, my youngest sibling was the one who needed her support the most. I don't know why, but the coldness in her voice was what pierced my heart.



Was it just because we were the only ones in the house that made me feel seen in Pangasinan? It was as if someone never cared about what I did or did not, as long as I lived my life like a typical child.

She was the type of person whom you would think is so full of hope. Despite having gone through so many conundrums, you would still see the joy in her eyes—that's what I love about her. Every time we talked; every time we met; every time we're together, she would then proudly tell me how happy she still is with her life.

I truly cherish forever the moments that we shared together—especially when for the first time, my *nanay* made me feel that there exists a love I deserve. But suddenly, I received the news that my *nanay* joined my *tatay* in heaven when I was accomplishing my robotics research paper. She passed away due to a chronic kidney problem that she endured over months. My mother told me that my *nanay* did not want to burden any of her children by letting them know she was already dying with an ailment. She did not want us to worry about her. And it all came crashing down on me. I cannot help myself but to cry over my project, and the fact that I was not by her side when she was dying.

For the last time, we went to Pangasinan to process her funeral. Being the black sheep of the family, I presented myself as if I did not care at all. I went there with all the courage I could muster, but none of it mattered when I touched her cold hand for the first time again after years. It did not sink in me that the last time I saw her alive was during that summer, when we were both alone and the blanket was wide enough for the both of us.

I was still in disbelief. It could not register in my mind that my *nanay* was no longer here. As I tried to rummage through my memories, all I can remember is the pitch of her voice whenever she was looking for me while I was playing outside with my friends.

And then suddenly, the guilt took over my body. From the fact that until the end of her life, she took care of us—took care of me by not letting us know what she was enduring. While there I was, preparing for the upcoming Science and Technology Fair. I could not wait to tell her how much I prepared for this contest and how it was dedicated to her. Now, it would not happen.

My *nanay* was a loving person. I could distinguish her even with her back as she always wore flowery blouses with tied hair. When you look at her face, you would see her wrinkled forehead with loose cheeks. She was a typical grandmother, the type of grandmother who would hand you 500 pesos by shaking hands with you. And so, I really could not believe that she was now gone.

I could not imagine the fact that she died all alone while hiding her illness from us. That emotional weight did not sit well with me and I grew weaker from the unforgiving reality that until her last breath, all she could think about was us.

It became stronger. The grief became stronger. Her death has been slicing away the only part of me that knew what genuine love felt like. Her absence just emphasized that the love and protection I used to have can no longer be realized again.

All of our memories poured in one by one when I slept in our bed once again, but now without her. It has been a false reality for me to wake up once again by the delicious smell of fried rice and a sunny-side up egg in the morning. By that, the only thread that kept the black sheep intact with his family had been gone. It was so hard to live a life without my nanay. I tried to recover from the situation by making myself seem cold again, and perhaps now there would be no one to see me the way she saw me every morning.

When we went back to Bulacan, I crawled up in my bed realizing that the blanket that used to keep both of us warm in the chilly evening was the blanket I had been using ever since. It slipped from my mind that she put this red geometric textile blanket in my bag when I was about to go back home. Every time this blanket brushed my skin, its silkness reminded me of her care. I always thought she must have thought of me and folded this quietly.

Unlike before, I did not feel alone in Bulacan. I know that every time I would slumber, I would feel her presence. It was as if I got used to her presence even though she was not with us anymore. Now, I strived to be the person she wanted me to be: a loving son to his family.

This blanket has served as my indirect connection to my nanay. It always reminds me to go easy on life and to show more love to my family.

She was the only reason I never presented myself as the odd one out again in my family. And I thought it would end when she passed away. I just know that she deliberately put this blanket in my bag so that I could feel her presence every time I felt like I was being alienated again.

I never felt the same way as before after having experienced the love of a nanay. For once again, I tried to interact more with my family, especially with my siblings. I used to spend all of my time alone in my room and now I force myself to talk with them and play with them if the situation allows us. Because one thing I learned from my nanay was to never take every memory for granted. Although I was always hanging by a thread, I chose to view some situations not in a pessimistic way. I deliberately changed the way I lead my life because I know that this is how she wanted me to live.

The blanket she left with me never goes where the wind blows. Although sometimes I still feel that

I have been pointed out as someone strange again. This blanket chooses to not take the trend people are imposing upon me.

Every night, when I'm all alone again, when it is hard to fall asleep, I just feel the embrace of the blanket. And I remember her last act of love—to fold this blanket quietly and slip it into my bag without a word. I just knew that it is the kind of love I will spend the rest of my life trying to deserve.

READY... SET... GO!

Imari Venedict F. Bernardo

Tick-tock - tick-tock
how I wish the clock would stop,
freezing my overflowing thoughts on the spot,
to give my mind more time to catch up,
silencing the echoes of my endless
overthinking,
so my heart could stop feeling everything.

As time keeps running, my mind keeps racing,
trying to chase all the what-ifs and what could
have been,
giving me no rest, as if I could catch up in life
just by staying inside my head.
It feels like running through a thousand miles,
until sleeping becomes better than being
awake.

Tick-tock - tick-tock
Time keeps sprinting
turning me from seventeen to thirty-one in a
flash
Running out of breath before my first hop,
racing after the time that I lost,
and can never get back.

In the race of life, winning became a myth
while losing became the legend.
I was slowly fading,
with no one noticing.
Once seen as a hare,
I became the last kit left in despair.

Tick-tock - tick-tock
Life will keep rolling; time has no ending
Nothing will change as long as I remain
lost within my own shadow.
I may be in the last row
chasing what lies far ahead of me,
But I'll keep running
until I reach the finish line.



RED

Imari Venedict F. Bernardo



Red,
the first color our eyes could see,
after the light and darkness faded.
Its striking hue demands attention,
no matter how far it is located,
or how small its size may be.

Red,
the color of flowers we give to our loved ones
to express heart and passion.
But it can also be the color of anger and hatred,
a danger we never expect.

Red,
One of the boldest colors in our flag,
the one we looked up to as we sing our hearts out.
A sense of nationalism taught to us,
from childhood until we grow up,
a symbol of our freedom and our home.

Red,
the color used to mark
those who have the courage to stand
against those who are hungry for power.
But now it becomes the reminder of the blood
that flows from the wounds of what they have taken,
justified as “protecting the land”
they were so easily painted red.

Pillow Talk

Francesca Lorraine C. Alcantara

Disclaimer: The author does not support any actions and beliefs within this narrative.

Throughout my life, my mother — though having long passed, bless her — has taught me numerous things that I still follow on my day-to-day. The lessons from my younger years have become muscle memory. These were the essentials: how to talk, how to act, and how to look. Presentation was very important from where I came from. After all, politics didn't just involve the person in position — which was my father; the whole family was the face, as the face was the brand.

Though, not all of us talk like royalty. I was just a very big fan of theatre. I remember when I was a little girl, my mother would take me to Solaire to watch plays. It involved princesses and knights in shining armor, happy endings with a maiden saved. In a sense it may have imprinted on me, but the fact it stayed was more of my mother's fault. She was always about marriage with me.

I cannot blame her for it, securing positions was a numbers game in general. Being in one position was not enough as a family. If we wanted to last, other family members had to take positions elsewhere, while the younger members were under lesser responsibilities. I was next up for mayor. However, I really had no interest in this. What business did I have with serving the people when another one of ours could do it?

Fortunately, women like me had a million options; and unfortunately, the best option was marriage. Hence, that was where most of my mother's teachings came in.

He picked me up at 7pm in his dark blue Chevrolet. It was a fairly understated vehicle, not what I was expecting from someone of his family. If his car was anything to comment on, much more so were his clothes. Of course they weren't cheap! (God forbid if it were), I just didn't see it coming either.

See, I always saw his father making flashy campaigns, and his older brothers doing the same. There were care packages, free clinics and the occasional jingle. During election season his family and mine would compete for holding the position of mayor and we'd exchange seats almost every year. My father, having talked to our "opposition", proposed that we merge the two families together through marriage instead. That way, there would be no competition at all. He and I simply had to go on enough dates until we're both comfortable with each other to marry. It sounded easy, didn't it?

The problem was, I had to get him to *actually* want our marriage first. My pride cannot simply allow it, not when he looked at me with such bored eyes. Surely push-up bras were in season, no? I even did everything my mother said I should do: shave the legs, let the hair down, wear an elegant dress — but not too elegant so that he could see my cleavage.

I framed it like there were any better options. But seriously, if the best option were to be the bare minimum, can I even call myself a wife? What were my mother's teachings for?

"Are you ready?" I heard him ask me as I strapped my seat belt in.

"What for?"

"To go, obviously. Maybe you forgot something in your condo unit upstairs. I'm fine with waiting."

And let him stall? Absolutely not. So, I told him that we should hurry along as I was just *so* painfully excited to finally get to know each other.

Our first date was at Blackbird, a fine dining restaurant located in Ayala Triangle, Makati. The place was divided into three: the grill room, the cabin and the garden. We had our seats in the grill room — this was essentially the main dining area within the restaurant.

I sat across from him, naturally, while he browsed the menu.

Did you know my waist is 38cm and my hips are 45?

I pitched myself like a hooker. He didn't say anything. It was because I didn't actually say it. Take two.

"What do you think about my chest in this dress? I heard size is attributed to fertility."

Surely any man would love a family. Family was legacy and inheritance, and considering who his parents are, who wouldn't want healthy babies running around the villa? My mother knew men like the back of her own hand — and so do I, by extension.

Instead, he ordered us champagne and he gulped a whole glass down.

I will take that as a success. My flirtation skills were so out of this world that he had to get tipsy just to speak with me

Dinner went on in silence after that. I helped myself to a shrimp salad while he poked around his spinach gnocchi. We exchanged brief conversations. I found out about his likes and dislikes. I told him that despite living with maids my whole life, I could make a decent homemaker. He told me that he liked to go golfing every weekend. That sounded like I'd have the house all to myself in the future.

Then just like that, the date was over and he waved down our server to fetch us the bill.

"Do you want to split the bill tonight?"

"That wasn't what our families agreed on," I shot back, sounding more intrigued than disappointed. "Is this place out of your price range?"

“No, what?” He laughed. “It’s just what you ladies want these days, right? Splitting the bill.”

“I wouldn’t really generalize,” I said slowly. “I’m not one to stereotype someone so easily.”

He averted his gaze as if he had wronged me, but to be honest, I may have exaggerated then. He wasn’t really listening during our date. The words that left his mouth were empty pretty things, things that I can’t call compliments, such as that one: split the bill. The only thing that stuck to me was the fact about golf — because it was true.

However, I could not fault him for it either, because what was I doing in that whole time? I wore no padding, and yet I was full of it.

Our next dates were nothing of note. It was similar to the first, but with different words said each time. I tried my best to get him to see that this arrangement wouldn’t leave him with regrets, but he powered through each of our meetings with bottles of champagne and scripted responses. It was like I was some woman on the street, not another dynasty.

There was even one time when I directly asked him, “Do you even want this, do you want me?”

Then he said, as if it were obvious, “Of course I do. We need this, don’t we?”

It wasn’t that kind of need. I didn’t care if the merger would have us basically own our city. What I needed was him to look at me. My mother has never failed me once. The fact that we were even past five dates was an achievement on its own. Her teachings, the knowledge that she has passed down to me, it wasn’t in vain. This arrangement could only be considered a success if I have done everything I practiced.

Then, when I thought I was about to give up, it was on the tenth date that I saw him differently for the first time. I had no idea what had brought about it, but for once it was as if I was living in a dream.

We were at Blackbird again, for the sole reason of him wanting to have another bite of their spinach gnocchi. Our conversations were dull and exhausting. However, it was there in the candlelight that I had a revelation I could never erase from my mind.

It was ridiculous of me not to have noticed it so early, but perhaps it was in the candlelight that my eyes could finally adjust to his face properly. He never looked like a typical man — those rough edges and a fuzzy chin. My husband-to-be had the longest lashes I’ve ever seen, and lips that would’ve had me abandon any sense of propriety. If anyone were to glance at him from the street and describe him with a single word, they’d call him queer.

Not *that* queer, queer as in strange, queer as something almost ethereal.

I almost said something, a compliment maybe. I was disobeying my mother. Women don’t compliment the man, it was the other way around. He should’ve been complimenting me. What about my dress today? Did he like my makeup at all? Something like that, anything. I didn’t care if it was the most bare-minimum hollow compliment I’d hear in my life.

Say I'm pretty.

"You're unusually quiet today," he remarked, effectively snapping me out of my thoughts. "Do you want anything? I can order you another entrée if you don't like that one. Not everything in Blackbird tastes good."

"It's nothing. I'm just tired."

"Strange," he said. I could've sworn he was slightly amused by my lack of composure. How irritating. Then, he continued, "I rarely say things because you're very chatty, I hope you know that. This isn't an excuse, by the way, because I know exactly how it sounds. You were eccentric at first, but then it was pretty fun."

That wasn't the pretty I was looking for. I huffed, "That does sound more like an excuse if you keep adding onto it. You always look so bored."

"No, I only have a resting face. Was that why you were staring?"

"...I was staring?"

"Actually you were just looking at a spot behind me."

That was a very fast lie. He could be mayor in the next election if he kept that up.

"Hey, don't go backtracking now," I said while I leaned slightly over the table. "We're finally having a proper conversation and you're trying to leave me at a lie? That's not very polite. Mind you, I could just tell your father."

"What am I — seventeen? That's not going to do a thing."

"I don't care. Speak to me."

"If you promise you won't do that one-woman show again, you'll have me for the rest of the night."

I scoffed in disbelief afterwards. He said that as if I was paying him to go on dates with him. *You'll have me for the rest of the night, if you don't act ridiculous*, his words echoed in my head. Like what? Conversation? I could do "conversation". Actually, he and I have been doing "conversation" for about too many dates now. I was bored with the way he'd talk about golf, and how it was more networking than sport. I didn't care. I absolutely did not care.

"Fine, entertain me. You talk about something instead. I'd rather not lead whatever this idea is," I sighed.

"You're doing it again though?"

“Learn the difference between theatrics and personality. If we’re going to get married, you might as well start now.”

He slightly leaned over the table as well. Perhaps he had taken it as a challenge back then, which was good. I needed him to stay focused on that while I tried not to stare at his face too hard.

Unexpectedly, I found myself having fun. Well, I was having fun in the previous days as well, however that was because I was checking things off in my head, basing things off of muscle memory and what felt right. He told me something different this time, not things like golf or the likes and dislikes he kept changing; he was telling me about his family and how much he hated election season.

“The wins are basically between your family and mine if it comes to being mayor. I don’t see why everyone in my house was so excited over them,” he complained as he waved down our server for dessert.

“Maybe it’s the competition itself. Think about it, it’s like cockfighting. You have two strong chickens, exceptionally modified, one wins and gets the cash, the other loses but they still have dinner.”

He nodded like he was saying *touché*. “I was thinking it could be more mystical than that though. Are you religious?”

“Depends how religious,” I pursed my lips.

“The bare minimum of being a catholic religious.”

“Hm, I guess you can say I am.”

He stared at me for a moment, like he was trying to deduce whether I was lying or not. I wanted to laugh at him. *Look who’s being ridiculous now*, I’d think. On the other hand, I didn’t expect it to feel so unnerving. *Would it feel better if his pretty brown eyes stayed on mine in some other way? In the candlelight, where dark brown warmed into hazel?*

“Well, there was this belief my mother taught me. It’s Manifestation,” he started. “And before you come after me, this isn’t a type of hopeless delusion, this is real. You can call me superstitious all you want but some people were able to buy their own houses with this, you know? My family was able to win the election over yours in the last period because all of us were hoping for it.”

“Uhuh.”

“Don’t uhuh me. You’re reacting like you weren’t the one who acted crazy first. What the hell did you expect me to say when you asked me how your tits looked like on the first date?!”

I hadn't talked about it yet, but the ambiance in Blackbird was divine. Breasts? What breasts? In fact, the next table over had wonderful crispy chicken breasts on their plate. Maybe he was talking about that.

I still spoke though and went, "I don't know, a compliment."

"See, this is what I'm saying. You're hypocritical, and you better remember that!"

Id him to keep it down before the two of us got kicked out of the restaurant. It wasn't even a question if he fetched me home in complete silence. He did. The air was thick in that dark blue Chevrolet. The radio was dead, and none of us turned it on to fix it. Meanwhile, I wanted to melt into the leather seats and never face him again.

But it was at the end of the tenth date that he kissed me for the first time — not on the lips, no, he was very polite. It was a peck on the forehead, one of the sweetest things he has ever done after acting like an awkward statue for so long. Was it an apology? A nonverbal way to say he enjoyed it too? I wanted him to say I was pretty. That was not what men did when they thought a woman was pretty. That was what men do if they thought a woman had entertained them enough to warrant a reward.

I returned to my unit, my head spinning. I wanted to cry.

I don't understand. He kissed me. Shouldn't I be happy? Jumping for joy, telling all my friends. My husband-to-be finally expressed affection for the first time and I didn't have to do what my mother taught me at all! Amazing! Isn't that great?

Yet the sensation of his lips against my forehead burned into the very pores of my skin, prickling and hot, as if the gentle weight of him had never left.

I was disgusted.

I was disgusted by the kiss.

In my search for comfort, I saw the warm streetlights below me, and I saw the candlelight back at our table again. His soft brown eyes fanned by long lashes, and the lips my eyes had been gravitating toward the entire night. It was warmer than I thought, but my tears flowed down my cheeks. It wasn't enough to ease the ache in my chest. I was devoid of satisfaction. The idea of us sharing a future could die if I didn't pull myself together.

The mayoral position I didn't want was the reason why I decided to do this in the first place. This marriage could keep me from that responsibility completely. I did not want a life in the office. I wanted to enjoy the accumulated wealth of my name. I wanted to live in a fantasy of being a princess who was protected by a knight in shining armor, my husband-to-be, just like the play I saw as a child.

Marriage was an opportunity for a woman like me. Marriage was the best choice for me. I did not care if he would one day want three children to replace him. I cared whether this whole arrangement was going right or wrong, and it was all going wrong — not because of him, because of me!

On the eleventh date, we had found ourselves in another fine dining restaurant. I took no effort in remembering the place, nor ordering what I wanted. I let him choose for me, and I engaged politely.

The eleventh became the twelfth, the twelfth became the thirteenth. He was talking more than I was, going on and on about manifestation, copying the same ridiculous theatrics that I'd do when it came to me trying to be a good match for him. Sometimes he'd say things I wouldn't have thought of saying, earning us strange looks from other patrons on nearby tables. Then, there was this one that had me nearly spit out my champagne and ditch him:

You should try it sometime, he'd say. When you manifest something, you imagine you already have it. For example: I wish I had six pack abs so chiseled, girls would call it pandesal.

Then every after each date, it was either another kiss on the forehead or a hug. My disgust was not a one-off event; it intensified with each ride home. There was no reason to be so revolted. He was clean, neat even. The perfume he wore wasn't those nose-piercing scents men's bottles were infamous for. The way he'd dress himself made him look effortlessly polished, emphasizing the broadness of his shoulders, the slimness of his waist. My eyes would trace every part of him across the table with each dinner. Why was it that I'd look at him with hunger when the candlelight finally hits? The answer struck me.

He was soft.

So very soft. A man so gentle that a person across would call him queer. His strangeness, something that I couldn't place, his strangeness that made him feel more delicate than any other.

He was so delicate that I could almost say he was a woman.

It was then I found my solace. I did not cry myself to sleep. I had thought to myself of the image. He was already halfway there anyway. He asked me to split the bill like he was broke. He'd say something embarrassing instead of something suave. He was more woman than I ever was in his passivity. The only problem was that he didn't look like one.

I did not pray. I just thought with borderline intensity. A woman, a woman, may my husband be a woman. May he please be more beautiful than I? May he continue to act as he was but with a different face? Oh, how my yearning gripped me with such force. This hunger was uncontainable, bubbling underneath my skin. That man is my future, how could I not do it?

Then on the twentieth date, he grew his hair out. We were at Blackbird again. He was very attached to that spinach gnocchi. I didn't care though. This man looked ethereal in the candlelight.

"You look homeless," I said.

"Ouch. And what for?"

"Look at your hair, it's all long and shabby. I hate it."

"Oh this? It's not that long, it's only touching my ears. I thought I could try something different today."

No, it's not. It's long enough to reach your lower back. Don't say such things.

I didn't say that out loud but he ordered a whole glass of champagne to down the whole thing within a single gulp.

Back on our first date, I took that gesture as him being too nervous to like me. Now that I saw it again, that was definitely from nerves. I didn't push too hard, did I? He can't leave. We had twenty dates in.

On the following one after that, I told him that he and I should proceed with the wedding before anything else went wrong. He asked me what was wrong and yet I couldn't tell him. The most satisfying answer I could provide was that I simply felt like it. He didn't buy it at first so I tried to woo him by taking the two of us on a shopping trip.

Neither of us can resist something like that. Forget the dinner dates where he could do an easy bail. I could drag him through every aisle through the shopping center and do anything we wanted. At first I started with something small like those cute flowery tops I saw or perhaps some skinny jeans that could look great on my figure. Then, dresses, I tried them on first, tried to be charming, and jokingly told him to try it on.

It would look better on you, I remember saying.

And he laughed at me like it was stupid. No way! I'm a man.

My husband-to-be had no idea that I had been seeing him with a curvier frame by then.

Shopping trips turned into ring fittings and ring fittings turned into family discussions. Our respective sides seemed satisfied with the outcome of our arrangement and deemed it right that he and I must be in charge of the venue.

We settled for Tagaytay Highlands, my choice and my mother's same wedding venue decades ago. I thought it would be rather symbolic, and also special, since he and I are continuing her legacy in a way (and whatever legacy of his that he was trying to maintain).

It was a quiet forest area filled with pine trees, boasting a clear shot of Taal, a horse ranch and essentials—such as a hospital that stood about a few meters away from the condominiums, but deeper into the woods was this neighborhood of huge log cabins. The wedding ceremony itself had remained a fuzzy memory for me. The dress itched and dug into my skin while I accidentally ate my hair under the veil. It was more excitement than nerves; I was the happiest I've ever been. Once he lifted my veil, I didn't see a man from an opposing political family, I saw a wife staring back at me.

Once the honeymoon came, it marked the time he and I shared a bed for the first time, a particularly cold night in December.

The sheets were smooth, and his bath wash from his recent shower filled my senses. Exhausted from the wedding, I entertained myself by staring at his face. It was almost the same as what I had seen in the candlelight, except his hair was longer and his skin was smooth.

Then he said, "What are you staring at?"

"Nothing in particular," I hummed in turn.

"You can admit you're staring at the window behind me."

"Well, I'm not."

It was truly a comforting sight, to see his superstitions turn out to be true. Forget Manifestation having the power to give someone things they have always dreamed of, this was a much higher plane of what I wanted. Houses were so worldly, and a good body was too shallow, what was lying next to me in bed was something more indescribable.

I have rewritten him, and thus he was mine. My mother was truly a wonderful teacher, I should thank his mother too for passing on such a belief.

To close the night, I then asked him, "Shall we get to it then?"

"As long as you drop the theatrics for tonight, then I'm freely yours."

"You should learn the difference between theatrics and personality." I smiled. "That's the secret to a happy marriage with me."



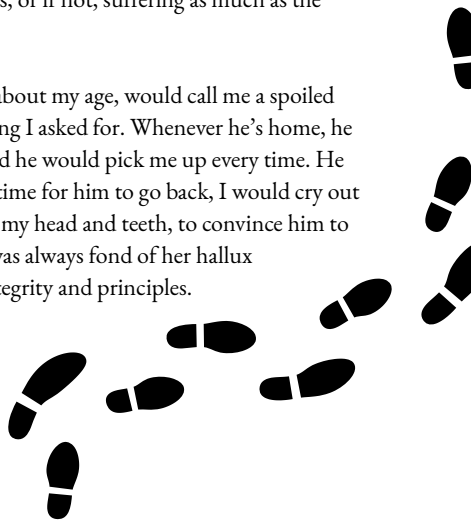
Pinky Toe Promise?

Rhee Arcilla

A typical human foot consists of five toes: the hallux or the big toe, long toe, middle toe, ring toe, and the pinky toe. For as long as I can remember, I see my foot toes the way I see my family. My big toe is like my father; my long toe is like my mother; the middle and ring toes are my brothers and sisters, respectively; and my pinky toe is me because I am the youngest child, the sixth of my parents' children. Back in seventh grade, for a recitation point, I explained why I thought so. Whenever I try to wear an ill-fitting shoe for my foot, to make room for the bigger toes, the pinky toe has to move a little bit, then a little bit, and a little bit, until it reaches its limit and becomes sore.

Whenever a family is going through a hardship, it is somehow overlooked how the youngest is the one suffering the most, making the adjustments, or if not, suffering as much as the other toes, or the other members of the family.

I was always a daddy's girl; my cousins, who are just about my age, would call me a spoiled brat because my father would get me almost everything I asked for. Whenever he's home, he would carry me on his back on our way to school, and he would pick me up every time. He never stayed at home for a long time, so when it was time for him to go back, I would cry out loud, pretend that my tummy was hurting, as well as my head and teeth, to convince him to stay, and he would, at least for a day. The pinky toe was always fond of her hallux father—she always saw him as a mighty man with integrity and principles.





I (in red dress) and my cousins.

For a couple of times a year, my mother and I would visit him in Manila for a few days. Whenever we are there, he would take us to the mall, eat, let me play, and buy me toys and new clothes. On some days, he would give Mama money to buy me CDs of Barbie movies, and would make sure that Mama cooks my favorite meals. When the time comes that Mama and I have to go back to Bicol because the vacation's over, I would cry my heart out at the Raymond Bus Terminal in Cubao, pleading with Papa to go home with us and just work in the province. Then, Papa, with teary red eyes, would excuse himself to go to the restroom. Minutes would pass, and I would cry as hard as I could because Papa had not come back yet, and the bus was already leaving.

Most of the time, our communication would be through phone calls. He would call Mama and would ask if I still have allowance, if I had already eaten, and how I am doing. He would also send money to buy me new clothes. My older siblings, especially my preceding sister, who is six years older than I, would sometimes get jealous of how I was treated favorably by our parents, especially by Papa, but Mama would tell her, "It is because she's the youngest. Ang baby ng pamilya."

It was a sunny morning in June 2016. My mother was doing my hair as I watched my innocent reflection in the mirror; we were getting ready for school when all of a sudden, Mama received a call from my father. Panic started creeping into my Mama's eyes as her voice was shaking while talking to Papa. The nine-year-old me could not guess what was happening—all I knew was that Mama started packing things to go to Manila immediately, while my brother was the one who, instead of Ma, dropped me off at school.

Papa was confined in Delos Santos Medical Center in Quezon City due to a heart attack that took place while he was working. He needed an operation to be saved. Months had passed, and Mama still hadn't come home yet.



Papa confined in hospital in 2016

Amidst being a daddy's girl, it's no mystery to me that Papa wasn't the perfect husband to Mama. He had multiple affairs with different women, all while being married to Mama and a father to us. During my early years, I had not yet grasped the intensity of that. I thought it was normal because Mama is still married to him, after all. Looking back, there were a lot of firsthand experiences where I witnessed Papa having an affair. I was in kindergarten, a few minutes before he dropped me off at school, he made a call to his then-mistress and gave me something for me not to tell Mama. Of course, I did tell Mama, but if there were actions taken, I am not so sure. When I was the first of my class in 2014, Papa was supposed to accompany me to the stage to receive my medals, ribbons, and certificates, but a while before I was called, he was out there somewhere, talking to his mistress. Papa gave me a tablet in 2015, which contained a video of him dancing with his mistress that my sister and I saw.

The confusion about everything had not yet begun until we moved to Makati for good. It was September 2016 when I was picked up by my brother from Bicol to Makati. Ever since my Papa's hospitalization, our relationship has not been like how it used to be. I became distant, maybe because I had realized what kind of husband he was to Mama. I transferred to Fort Bonifacio Elementary School and tried finding new friends in our neighborhood in West Rembo. My father continued with his dialysis and went to work again, after roughly a year.

It was 2017 when Mama checked Papa's phone. She found something that crushed my whole family, my whole being. Suddenly, the whole world in front of me collapsed, dropped dead. I am not my father's pinky toe anymore. What Mama saw was a conversation between Papa and his mistress; she had just given birth to a baby boy, and Papa was the father. He got pregnant with the woman he had been with for two years already at that time.

All my life, I have always known that I was the pinky toe. Until, suddenly, I wasn't. My young mind could not easily accept that I wasn't the youngest child of Papa anymore. I was supposed to be the baby, princess, and the favorite, but that changed when Sky was born. Maybe that explained why Papa, just like me, got distant. I may be Mama's youngest, but not my father's.



Years later, Mama would check the woman's Facebook account once in a while, and every time she did, a new picture was posted. Picture of them being in Jollibee, a picture of Papa carrying Sky, and a picture of them fresh from the church after the baptismal. Now and then, my parents would argue, Mama would ask Papa to leave, but he wouldn't. He would go home to us, but he also goes to his other family. Papa kept denying that he was visiting his son and mistress, but the posts Mama would find proved otherwise. It was just now that I realized how sick my father really was.

Eventually, Sky and his mother moved to Visayas. Papa had no contact with them anymore. During the years that they have not been in contact, of course, Papa had a few affairs with other women. Sky's mother died of cancer in 2023. I used to believe it was karma that took her life away. Maybe it was the Lord's (if He exists and cares) way of apologizing for letting my father break the tower. But that's not fair to Sky; he was just a kid, and still is, who lost a mother.

My mother and I had to move back to Bicol the same year. After just a couple of months there, my father had asked Mama if she could take care of Sky. As the kind-hearted woman that my mother is, she agreed. Living with Sky was difficult for me, especially since I got used to being the pinky toe of the family. Last March 2025, my father finally retired from his work and went to Bicol. We were living on the same roof: me, Papa, Mama, and Sky, and there I witnessed how my Papa treated his new pinky toe favorably. That used to be me. Until the present day, Sky has been living with my parents in Bicol. And maybe, I despised my mother a little bit for forgiving and forging and forgiving and forgiving and forgiving and forgiving Papa every time. Every single time.



New Year's Eve 2026

Sky truly is the pinky toe; he is the one affected the most because of the things that have happened. He has to switch places many times, he lost his mother, and is not fully accepted by his half-siblings just yet, or at least me. I am still finding the courage to accept everything as they are and to accept Sky as he is because, after all, he is just a kid who did not have an option to choose what kind of parents to have.

To Sky,

You are the tower that broke me. But just like me, you did not ask for all of these. I pinky-toe promise that ate will finally accept you.

Love,

Ate Belay

To Papa,

You were the one who built my tower and also the one who ruined it. For a decade now, I have been praying for you to change. For the little girl that I used to be and for the little kid you used to be, I will keep praying and hoping. But for Mama, Sky, ates and kuyas, and other illegitimate children you might have, I hope you get all the karma you deserve. Fuck you and your never-ending well of fucks.

To Mama,

I hope in another life, you get to be loved properly, and you never meet Papa. Ma, *gets na kiia*.

THE DOPPELGÄNGER

Samantha Leander



As a kid, I thought doppelgängers were creepy. A doppelgänger was someone who looked just like you. If someone could look just like you, they could easily come in and steal your life if they met you, knew your loved ones, and your work. So imagine my face when I visited my mom's house and saw a doppelgänger that looked like me.

Well, not exactly me. She was a cisgender doppelgänger of me. She had long hair, no binder, and was wearing the traditionally feminine clothes I had that my mom said she had given away. We stared at each other for a few seconds, processing everything. "You must be Luke," she said, breaking the silence.

My mom saw me at the door. "Oh, I didn't know you were coming today. You just visited two weeks ago."

"Is it wrong for me to visit?" I said.

I entered the house. "I see you have a guest," I said.

"Oh, no. She's not a guest. She's staying here. I realized since you moved out, I could make extra money by having a tenant move in. This is Lucy."

My stomach churned, hearing my deadname. This cisgender doppelgänger not only lived with my mom but also had my deadname? The way my mom said the name with no hesitance. As if I didn't have that name before.

We sat at the dinner table where my mom prepared *kare kare*, my favorite dish. I know she didn't know I was coming. Could it be Lucy's favorite dish? At the dinner table I observed Lucy. She was me, but better. Everything about her, not just that she was a woman, was perfect. She held her fork and spoon the right way, unlike me who held it as if I was holding a stick. She sat with perfect posture. I didn't sit with perfect posture as a kid, always hunched, trying to not put so much attention to my chest. And even though she looked like me, she didn't have that resting bitch face that I have.

"So, Lucy..." I said. "What do you do for a living?"

"I'm an industrial engineer." She said, smiling politely.

Even her job was an upgraded version of my job, which was being a product designer. My mom wanted me to be an engineer.

Until now, my mom hadn't said a word about Lucy. Is she happy now? Happy that she has a person that is almost like a daughter? She might as well be. She lives with her, eats with her, wears my stupid girl clothes.

"Luke, are you okay? You haven't touched your food." My mom said.

My heart sank. This was the first time my lived name slid so easily from her tongue. My mom never liked using that name. She just doesn't see me as her child anymore. She doesn't have a son. She has Lucy.

My first thought was, I'm gonna kill her. I'm gonna kill Lucy and then unbind and grow out my hair and wear the clothes she stole from me. But no, if my mom was gonna have one child again, I'm not letting her get a daughter. Who is she to have a perfect daughter? My mom doesn't get to choose that.

But I wasn't gonna kill Lucy now. I'd have to plan it. I'd have to make sure my mom wouldn't find her or worry about her. I'll do it at the end of the month. So that it would seem like she just found a new place to live. I would kill her, then pack her things, then leave a message saying she's leaving.

I visited my mom a few more times before the end of the month. And in that time, I learned more things about Lucy. She loved the beach like my mom. I hated the beach, I didn't like the water or having to wear beach clothes. Lucy was also very organized, always cleaning the room she rented. She always helped on chores. Everything about her just made me feel that I was a bad kid. And my mom loved her. My mom would always pass the food to her first. She would serve the food to her, and she would always cook *kare kare* on the weekends. Why'd it have to be on the weekends when I visit? She would always ask Lucy what she thought, what she did at work, what she'd like to watch on TV. What about me? How about what I thought, what I did, what I wanted to watch?

By the third week, I was helping out doing chores around the house. I would iron out clothes and Lucy would be beside me, folding them. My mother worked in the kitchen, preparing lunch. I went to the bathroom for a break, and after a short while, I heard something heavy fall from the room I was working on.

My mother and I rushed to the room and saw Lucy's hand slightly burnt and the clothes ruined from the heat of the iron.

My mother came to Lucy's aid. "Lucy, what happened?"

Lucy was almost in tears. "Luke went away and the iron was still on my clothes so I tried to remove it. But it seems I touched the iron from the wrong side and burnt myself."

That's bullshit, I thought. How can you not know where to hold an iron?

My mother looked at me, furious. "Luke, you should not have left Lucy alone! Now she's hurt. And look, her dress is ruined, too."

That's not her dress, that's mine.

When my mother left the room to look for first aid supplies, I knew I wasn't imagining it when I saw Lucy's subtle and cunning smile from my peripheral vision. When I turned to look at her, it was gone.

It was the end of the month and I knew my mom did groceries on Sundays so I waited close to the house until she left. I knocked at the door, knowing Lucy would answer and she did. We were both inside and she said she was preparing something in the kitchen. I told her I'd help her. *This was going to be it*, I thought. I would grab a knife then do a clean hack.

I grabbed the sharpest kitchen knife I could find. I crept slowly at the back of Lucy. It will all be over in a moment.

"Luke, can you slice this for me?" Lucy asked.

I was silent, leaving no answer. It's now or never. My hand started to feel heavy. I can't hesitate. If I hesitate now, I won't be able to kill her.

I stabbed her in the back, at the region where her lungs could be in. Lucy gasped for air, as the knife punctured her lung. I took the knife out. She turned to face me and I looked straight into her eyes as I hacked her. I saw her lips quiver and heard her cry my name, as if I betrayed her.

"Luke?" She softly whimpered.

It felt good. I stabbed Lucy again, this time in the abdomen. I did this multiple times and the kitchen started to stain red from her blood. Every scream and cry Lucy made gave me satisfaction. You could almost see the corner of my mouth turn into a twisted smile.

When it was obvious she was dead, I let out a sigh of relief.

I heard the door from the front unlock. I dared not to cover my act. When my mother saw Lucy, her dear replacement of a daughter stabbed, she dropped her things from shock. I stood in front of the body and pointed the knife at my mother, crying from the loss of Lucy.

"It looks like I will be moving back here." I said.

My Dad Says I Should Stop Being Average

Shiloh Margaret Telebrico

Ever since college started, I have not once felt like I actually belonged in the rooms I have my classes in. Call it imposter syndrome or what, but studying in one of the most prestigious universities in the country does things to your self esteem—each *pasang awa* being celebrated, and mediocre grades being relieving.

One of my biggest support systems is my father. Through every hell week, he would cook me pork sinigang (it is my favorite *ulam*) without me having to ask, or buying me coffee amidst completing my deadlines. He is the first to celebrate my *pasang awa*'s with me and the first to reassure me that I'll be just fine.

Although, it wasn't really like this before. I remember being 11, just in my room, when my father would barge into my room, drunk, just to whisper: *You're just average. Do better.* I'd blink at him, and he'd close my door. *What the hell*, I'd think. I wouldn't mind, since I thought it was just the alcohol talking, but eventually it happened every now and then that I started to think he actually meant it.

Mommy, am I not doing enough? I asked my mom. I wanted a second opinion. She asked why, and I'd tell her about my dad's remarks whenever he came home drunk. *'Wag mo nang pansinin 'yun. Lasing lang, alam mo naman na*, she said. I laughed and shrugged it off, but she didn't even answer my question.

Before all this, being average had never even occurred to me. I was naturally a hardworking student. Straight A's, academic awards, et cetera, et cetera, you name it. I was decked out in medals every competition and in certificates every year-end. With each award I brought home, my parents would beam with pride. This was what I was used to.

Just as I had gotten used to achieving, my parents had gotten used to it, too. Coming home with exemplary grades was routine, and anything lower was equivalent to failure. But I was not too bothered. I knew I could deliver, anyway. Until I couldn't.

I started to feel the pressure from my parents. Every family dinner would be my having to prove that I'm still achieving, be it in competitions or stellar grades. There was no room to be just average if all this time, I wasn't.

Come grade school graduation practice, I was announced as salutatorian. When I heard my name, the room cheered—my friends and teachers all congratulated me. But I, on the other hand, went blank for a second. My mind immediately went to my parents. What would they say? *Holy shit, I'm just second.* So close, yet so far. I forced a smile in front of everyone. I wanted to crawl into a hole.

I went home and was greeted by my dad. I told him of the news, and he seemed to be pleasantly surprised, but I was convinced that he was disappointed. I didn't trust that he was actually happy about this, which went to show how I saw myself because of my parents', especially my dad's, expectations from me.

Anything that wasn't first was disappointing. The words my dad used to whisper came rushing back. I felt so unhappy with what I had achieved. Second out of 200 something was definitely something to be proud of, but I wasn't. I wanted to be, but I just couldn't be.

Seventh grade came out to be way worse. Along with being salutatorian, I was granted a scholarship; to keep it, I had to maintain being in the top 2. Now, I felt pressure from myself as well. Looking back, this might have been just my trying to search for validation. If my parents could be proud of me, maybe I'd find it in me to be proud of myself, too.

When the first quarter grades were released, I had gotten an A. Only 4 got a higher grade of A+ in the batch. I was not one of them, evidently. On top of that, I got the news that I didn't make it as our school's representative for a math competition. The ride home was full of fear and disappointment. I'd have to hear my parents comparing me to the dumbass tryhards in my batch again.

I tried to avoid my parents with everything I could. I already knew how this was going to end. My dad called me to his room, asking me what had happened to me. I clearly disappointed him, but honestly, I didn't see why it was that big of a deal.

Attempts to hold back my tears were made. My dad told me to stop crying and to answer him properly. I choked back all my words, ultimately just not being able to speak at all. I couldn't think of any answers as well. I shared the same disappointment for myself as he did. Now, I think I was disappointed only because he was.

I continued to cry myself to sleep that night. I hated every single moment. Every *bakit ba hindi mo na kaya?* felt like boulders dropped on top of me. I wished they were real and crushed me instead. I didn't have an answer either, all I knew was that I didn't want to hear any of it again.

My dad didn't talk to me for a whole week after that. I was thirteen years old with an avoidant father all because I didn't do as good as the other 4 people in my batch. In that week, every time we'd have dinner together, the silence killed me. It lingered as a reminder of my incapability to go beyond what he thought was being average. It felt like to him, I was not his daughter, but some pet being trained to win competitions. Hell, maybe I would have been better off as a dog in those dog pageants.

Over time, I built up resentment towards my dad. It got to a point where I didn't understand anymore why he put so much pressure on me. Okay, I was his unica hija. Okay, he wanted to push me and see me succeed. I was a kid comparing my achievements with my father's, trying to see if I would ever be on par with him.

Over time, I would also realize why my father pushed me so much. He was not as well off as we are now, and he only succeeded by putting in extra work. He wanted to see me stand out to be successful. Being average meant being just like everyone else. Being extraordinary meant being something better—something greater.

I just wasn't sure if I was ready to be great. Nor if I even wanted to.

After seventh grade, I would gradually see my dad change. His what happened's would then become it's okay's. Perhaps he saw the toll of his pressure on me. Perhaps he was scared to lose me completely. I would never know, but I'm happy that he seems to be satisfied with what I can give without having to lose myself in the process.

Now that I'm older and wiser, I like to look back at what has shaped me. My dad (now also older and wiser) does not pressure me anymore. I think he has accepted that I am my own person, and put in his trust in me.

Sometimes, I still think about how my dad viewed me before. At one point, if you asked me what my greatest fear was, I would have replied with being average. I think I just feared disappointing people, especially my dad.

But along with growing up, for me, also meant accepting mediocrity. We all grow past that ex-gifted, now burnt out student phase. If being average meant being happy with myself, then let me be it.